captives were his ruin.’[1]) Baz Bahadur had reclaimed his kingdom when it was thus unhelmed, but he was soon ousted by another of Akbar’s great commanders, Abdullah Khan the Uzbek, who had led the briefly victorious Mughal vanguard against Hemu during Tardi Beg’s ultimately shambolic defence of Delhi. And farthest of all, some 700 kilometres south of Agra and over double that distance from Kabul, pushing into unknown land in search of fortune, there was a man called Asaf Khan, about to take on the formidably rich and famously beautiful queen of Gondwana, Rani Durgavati.

Was it an empire, however, that Asaf Khan sought to expand? And if so, whose? In the few months of Humayun’s second innings in Hindustan, the padishah had had a republican dream. ‘[R]epeatedly’, according to Abul Fazl, Humayun had declared that he would ‘make several seats of government’ across the region ‘for the regulation’ of Hindustan. Thus, ‘Delhi, Agra, Jaunpur, Mandu, Lahore, Qanauj’ would all be ‘under the charge of a prudent, farseeing, subject-cherishing, and just officer’, capable of handling his territory independently, so much so that Humayun imagined he would need no more than a modest cavalry of 12,000 for his own imperial needs.[2] Indeed, Humayun had put his plan into practice: Nizamuddin writes that the chiefs who accompanied Humayun on his return to Hindustan ‘were most liberally rewarded, and each one was made the ruler of a province’. Humayun had had long years, after all, to think of how internal dissension – not least by his own brothers – had weakened his hold over the Hindustan he had inherited from Babur and tried to expand under his own banner. Perhaps he hoped that a more decentralized rule would also be more stable, or longer lasting.

Such proto-federalism was, in any case, the logic of the ‘conquest state’: to allow the most powerful military commanders to extract their own ‘salaries’ from assigned territories, and to pay others from the ‘treasuries of defeated enemies’.[3] This was why Adham Khan, Ali Quli and Sharafuddin were in the process of carving out virtually independent fiefdoms when Akbar interrupted them, causing understandable distress and resentment.[4]

It was not as if Akbar had any undisputed right to their loyalty, let alone any inalienable right to rule over them.

Leaving aside, for a moment, Abul Fazl’s epic tale of the Niru’un, there is